

PSYC1003

Dissociation & Dissociative Identity Disorder

Part 3: Dissociative Identity Disorder & Culture

A/Prof Simon Boag
email: simon.boag@sydney.edu.au

DID & culture

Review of DID cases (2000-2010):

- “Most cases of DID emerged from a small number of countries & clinicians. In addition, documented cases occurring outside treatment were almost non-existent” (Boysen & Van Bergen, 2013)
- **80% cases found in North America**
- Boysen, G. A. & VanBergen, A. (2013). A review of published research on adult dissociative identity disorder: 2000-2010. *J. Nerv. Ment. Dis.* 201, 5-11

Cultural manifestations?

Western bias? v. few DID cases in India, Japan, Oman, China, Iran, etc.

- Different cultural manifestations?



“In African, Asian, & other non-Western countries ... DID usually takes the form of pathological possession experiences which are more congruent with a conception of self as not separate or individual” (Dorahy, et al, 2014)



Different cultural manifestations of DID?

“In certain (e.g., mainstream Western) cultures, [DID] is consonant with a fragmentation of *internal identities*; in other (e.g., non-Western) cultures it may accord with *external spiritual entities* that take control of the individual” (Dorahy, et al, 2014)





Possession states & DID

“The majority of studied societies & cultures have conditions in which another entity is understood to have taken over the body of an inflicted individual, ie., possession states”

(Kluft, 1996)

- **Evidence for the reality of DID? cf. DSM-5**





Criticism of using possession states as evidence for DID



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Most traditional societies hold possession beliefs but:

- Different rates per society, different M/F rates, different displays of possession
- “... possession phenomena underscore the rule-governed & social nature of multiple identity displays” (Spanos, 1994)



Spanos (1994)

The frequency with which possession occurs varies greatly from one society to another. In some societies that hold possession beliefs, only a relatively small percentage of the population is ever defined as actually possessed. For instance, Wijesinghe, Dissanayake, and Mendis (1976) reported an incidence of 0.5% for a semiurban population in Sri Lanka; Carstairs and Kapur (1976) found a period prevalence rate in a rural population on the west coast of South India of 2.8%; and Venkataramaiah, Mallikarjunaiah, Chandra, Rao, and Reddy (1981) reported a prevalence of 3.7% in a different South Indian rural population. In other societies, the rates of possession are extremely high. For instance, in the villages of the Malagasy, speakers of Mayotte, Lambek (1980) reported that 39% of the adult women and 8% of the adult men were considered to be possessed. Relatedly, Harper (1963) reported that 20% of the women among the Havik Brahmins in Mysore, India, experienced possession, and Boddy (1988) found that in different years 42% and 47% of ever-married women more than 15 years of age in the village of Hofriyat in Northern Sudan had succumbed to possession. When



Reflection point

- **DID: Real or unreal?**
- *Note:* Even if DID shown to be a sociohistorical product this does not rule out genuine (trauma) cases of DID
- No doubt that traumatising occurs
- No doubt that personality disturbances exist

Trauma x Culture interaction (Dorahy et al 2014)

- *Culture might shape expression of DID*
- *Not all possession states indicate DID, but DID may take form of possession after trauma*



An example of a full manifestation of demonic possession



Trauma x culture interaction

“Understanding the aetiology of DID requires the amalgamation of several exposure, coping & developmental factors. These include traumatic experiences, family dynamics, child development, attachment ... & the role culture plays in constructing ‘alternate’ selves (i.e. embodied representations of the metaphor of ‘a different person’ [or spiritual being]) with separate attributes & specific memories for trauma” (Dorahy et al., 2014)



Questions?

